

The Knicks' Best Finals Path in Years

Caleb Ramsey

May 09, 2026

Executive Summary

Coming into the season, expectations were higher than they had been in years for the New York Knicks. With a deep collection of offensive talent, Mike Brown taking over, and the East wide open, the question became simple: if not now, when?

Now, that feels like the right question. Boston is already out. Indiana is no longer the same obstacle. Cleveland or Detroit still lie ahead, but New York is one win away from consecutive conference finals and would have a real case as the favorite against either team.

The bar has moved. Winning the East is no longer some far-off idea. The bigger question is whether this roster can actually hold up against whoever comes out of the West.

That question is interesting because of how they have gotten here. This has not been the old playoff formula where Brunson had to drag every late-clock possession home. He is still the organizer and tone-setter, but he has not had to do it alone. Through nine playoff games, New York has looked balanced, physical, and deep enough to make the Finals conversation real.

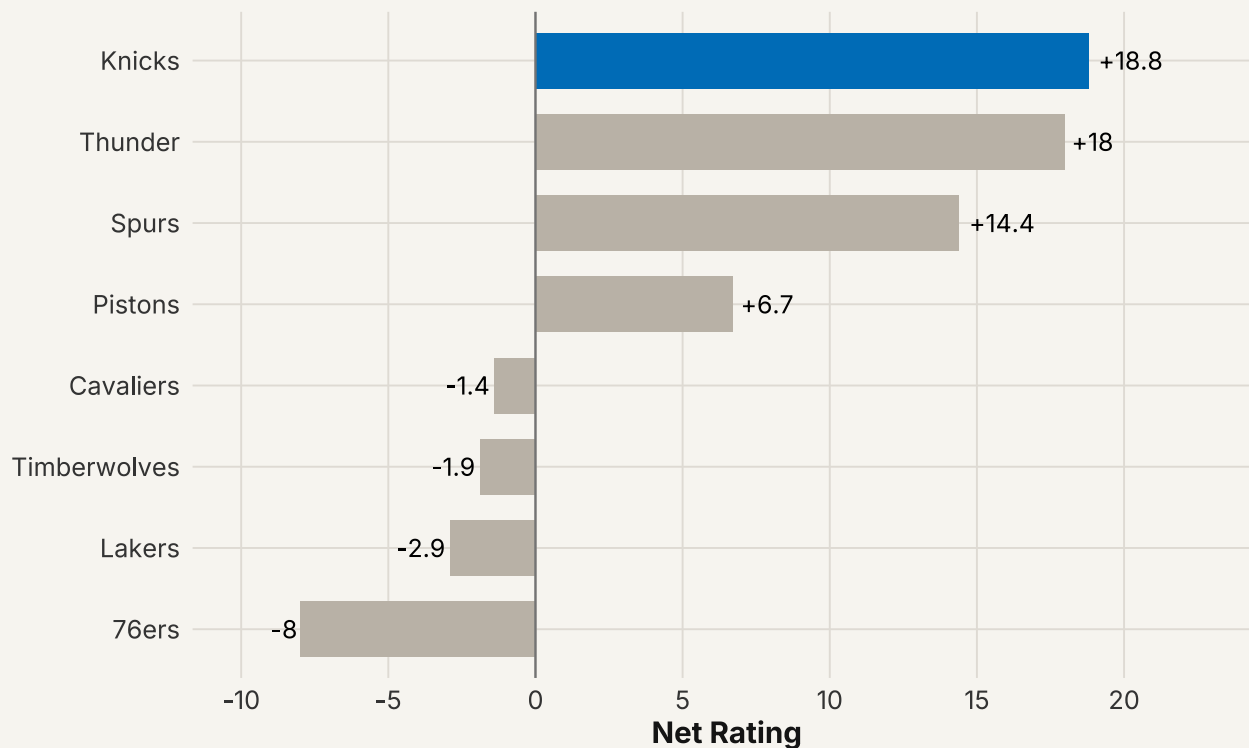
Where The Knicks Stand

Table 1: Remaining playoff teams by overall profile

Team	W-L	OffRtg	DefRtg	NetRtg	TS%	TOV%	OREB%	Pace
New York Knicks	7-2	122.3	103.5	18.8	62.2%	14.1%	32.6%	96.3
Oklahoma City Thunder	6-0	125.5	107.5	18.0	62.1%	12.7%	34.2%	96.1
San Antonio Spurs	6-2	115.7	101.4	14.4	59.1%	14.7%	28.8%	99.0
Detroit Pistons	6-3	109.7	103.0	6.7	55.4%	16.4%	33%	94.9
Cleveland Cavaliers	4-5	111.7	113.2	-1.4	57.5%	17.3%	34.9%	96.2
Minnesota Timberwolves	5-4	108.4	110.3	-1.9	54%	14.2%	31.7%	100.3
Los Angeles Lakers	4-4	106.5	109.4	-2.9	57.1%	19.2%	31.3%	93.1
Philadelphia 76ers	4-6	108.4	116.4	-8.0	55.2%	13.1%	25.3%	94.2

New York is in good company

The Knicks, Thunder, and Spurs have separated from the remaining field



Data: NBA.com | Viz: @Rambzee_

Figure 1: Net Rating among remaining playoff teams

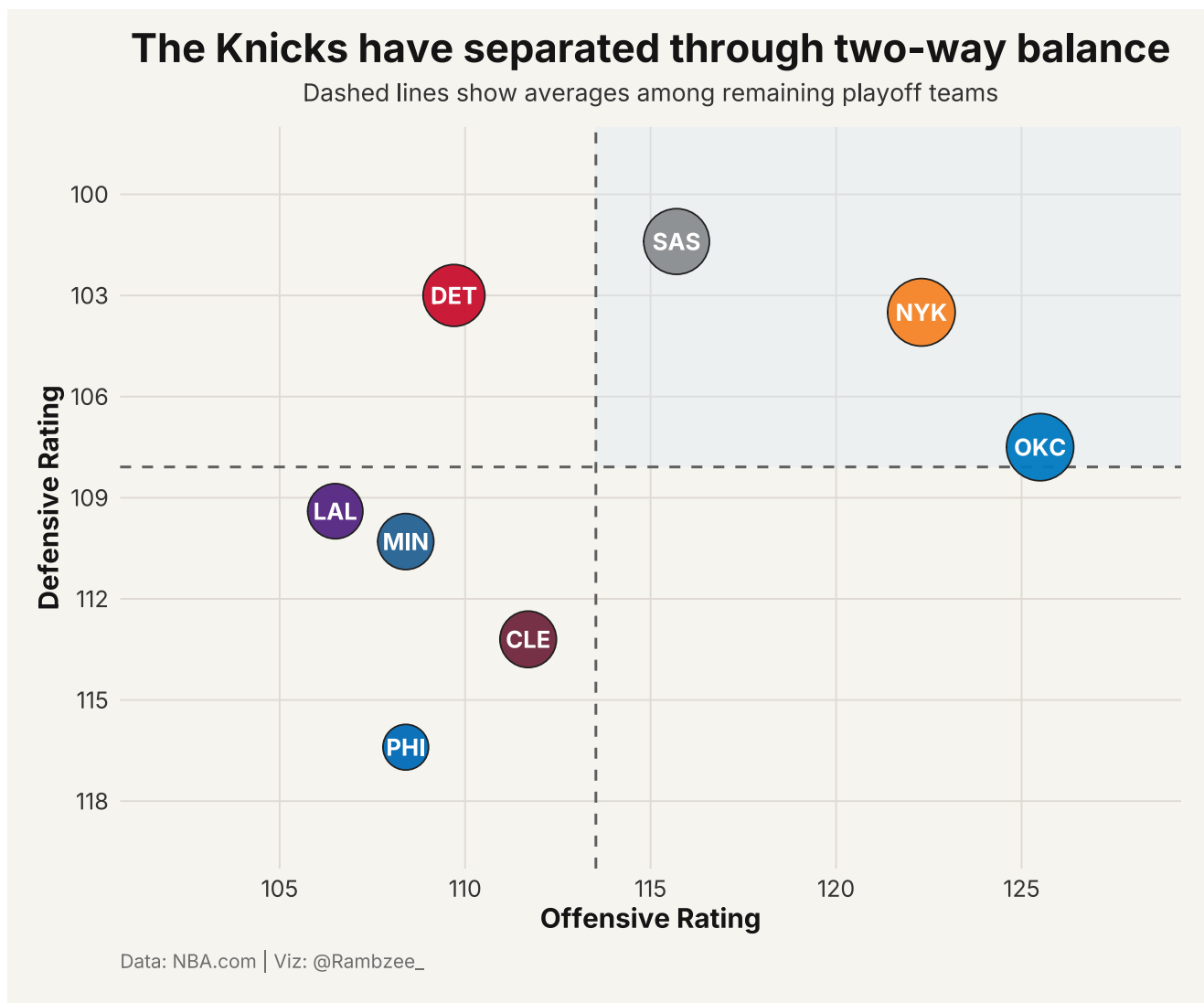


Figure 2: Offensive and defensive balance among remaining playoff teams

The Knicks have not just been good by East standards. Among the remaining teams, they combine the best Net Rating with an elite offense and a defense that has been strong enough to keep games from becoming pure shotmaking contests.

The Knicks Have Become More Interconnected

[H]

Table 2: Combined playoff production from Brunson, Towns, and Anunoby

PPG	RPG	APG	Avg TS%	Total +/-
66.8	20.6	13.6	69.3%	+41.8

The team-level leap starts with the Knicks' top three. Through eight playoff games, Brunson, Towns, and Anunoby have combined for 66.8 points, 20.6 rebounds, and 13.6 assists per game. Brunson is still the first name on the scouting report, but the burden is spread more cleanly than in past playoff runs.

Karl-Anthony Towns: More Than a Scoring Big

[H]

Table 3: Karl-Anthony Towns regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	BLK	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	FTr	TOV	+/-
First 76 Games	20.0	3.0	11.8	0.5	61.9%	55.7%	36.9%	5.5	40%	2.5	+5
Last 9 Games	17.4	6.2	10.7	1.4	72.8%	62.7%	46.1%	5.8	61.2%	2.9	+12.4

KAT's playoff run has been predicated on the poise and control he has given the Knicks. His assists have doubled from 3.0 to 6.2 per game, his free-throw attempts are up, his FTr has jumped from 40.0% to 61.2%, his blocks have climbed from 0.5 to 1.4 per game, and his efficiency has exploded to 72.8% true shooting.

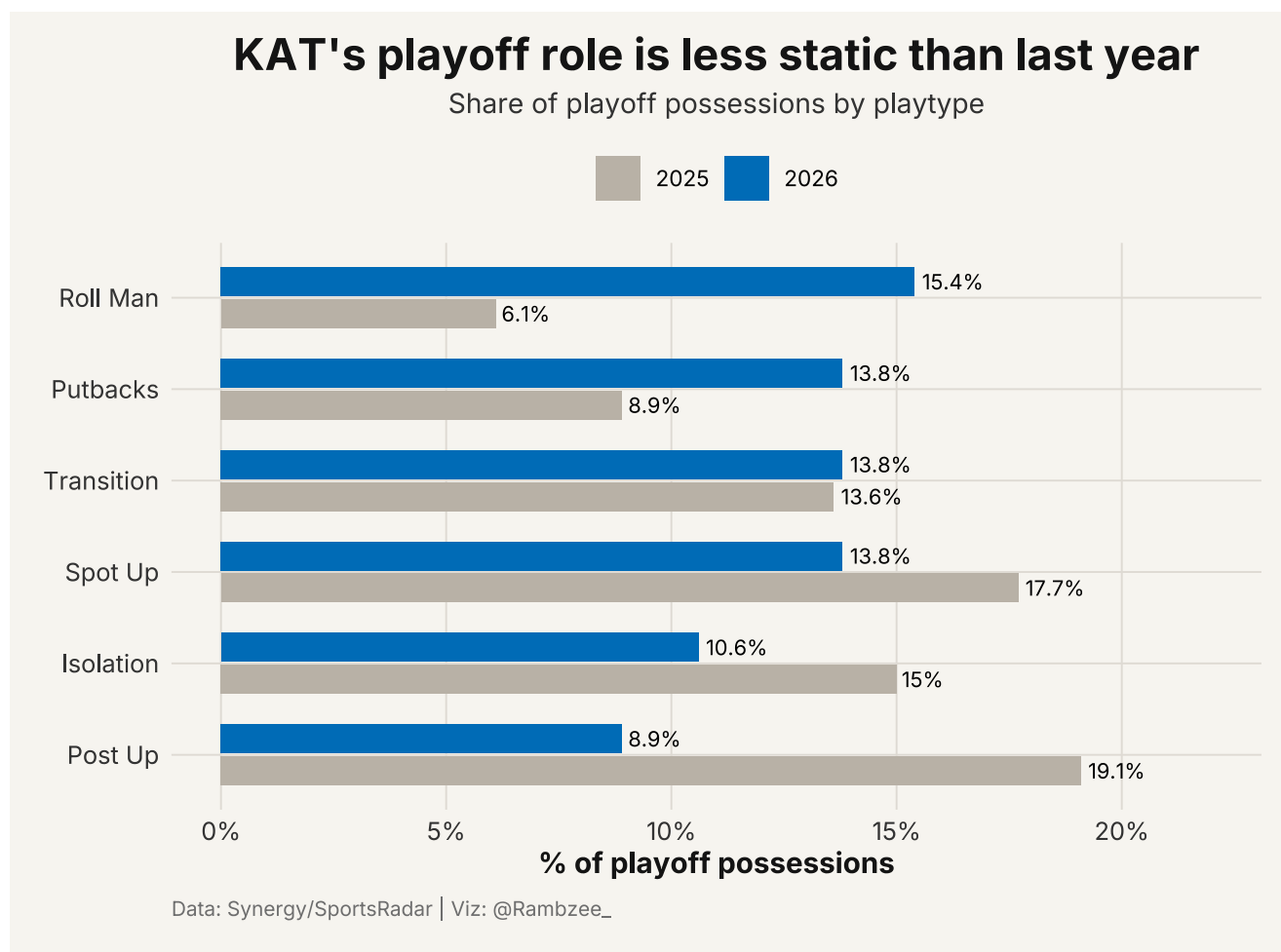


Figure 3: KAT playoff playtype distribution change. 2025 sample: 361 possessions. 2026 sample: 134 possessions through Game 2 vs Philadelphia; Game 3 excluded to capture the Knicks' offensive context with OG in.

The playtype shift explains a lot. Compared with last year's playoff run, KAT is spending less time in static post-ups and isolations and more time creating pressure as a roller, transition threat, and cleanup scorer.

He is catching the ball on the move, using his size near the rim, drawing help, and making the next pass when the defense reacts. That version is more useful, even if the scoring average is slightly lower, because his scoring, passing, foul pressure, and size are all working together.

KAT's Defense Deserves Its Own Note

Table 4: Knicks playoff WOWY lineup splits with KAT and Mitchell Robinson

Lineup	MIN	OFF	DEF	NET	NYK 3P%	OPP 3P%
Towns ON, Robinson OFF	249	123.9	103.5	+20.4	38.3%	33.3%
Robinson ON, Towns OFF	98	126.8	102.1	+24.8	37.7%	23.7%
Towns OFF, Robinson OFF	69	119.6	111.3	+8.2	36.7%	37.2%
Towns ON, Robinson ON	16	127.3	103.0	+24.2	42.9%	40%

[H]

Table 5: Knicks playoff performance with Towns on and off the floor

Lineup	MIN	OffRtg	DefRtg	NetRtg	3P%	Opp 3P%
Towns ON	265	+124.1	+103.4	+20.7	38.5%	33.7%
Towns OFF	167	+123.8	+106	+17.8	37.3%	28.6%
ON - OFF	—	+3	-4.5	+7.5	4.6%	4.7%

KAT's defense also deserves a note. The rim protection has stood out, but overall New York has defended well in his minutes without needing to pair him with Mitchell Robinson. That does not mean he has suddenly become a defensive anchor, but his minutes have not been something the Knicks need to hide. In fact, he's been good defensively, which is especially meaningful for a player whose playoff defense has often been questioned.

OG is the Perfect Role Player

[H]

Table 6: OG Anunoby regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	BLK	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	FTr	TOV	+/-
First 68 Games	16.9	2.2	5.3	0.7	62.3%	58.7%	38.8%	3.3	27.5%	1.8	+6
Last 8 Games	21.4	1.3	7.5	1.1	75.5%	67.2%	53.8%	4.6	38.1%	0.5	+14.8

[H]

Table 7: How the Knicks' top three have changed in the playoffs

Player	PTS change	AST change	REB change	TS% change	FTA change	TOV change	+/- change
OG Anunoby	+4.5	-0.9	+2.2	+13.2 pp	+1.3	-1.3	+8.8

OG's jump is the biggest individual playoff swing on the roster. He has gone from 16.9 to 21.4 points per game, jumped to 75.5% true shooting, and cut his turnovers from 1.8 to 0.5 per game.

That is not normal role-player variance, especially with the defensive workload he still carries. When Brunson or Towns create advantages, OG punishes the gap, the late rotation, or the clean catch-and-shoot chance. On the other end, he has taken turns on Jalen Johnson, CJ McCollum, Tyrese Maxey, VJ Edgecombe, and Paul George.

His absence is a major blow. The Knicks have enough shot creation to survive without him, but their title ceiling depends on his two-way impact. If they are going to reach the Finals, they likely need the version of the team they showed when OG was available.

Brunson Does Not Have to Carry Every Possession

[H]

Table 8: Jalen Brunson regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	BLK	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	FTr	TOV	+/-
First 75 Games	26	6.8	3.3	0.1	57.8%	52%	36.8%	5.7	28.3%	2.4	+4.7
Last 9 Games	28	6.1	2.4	0.0	59.7%	53.5%	37.5%	6.6	31.9%	2.4	+14.6

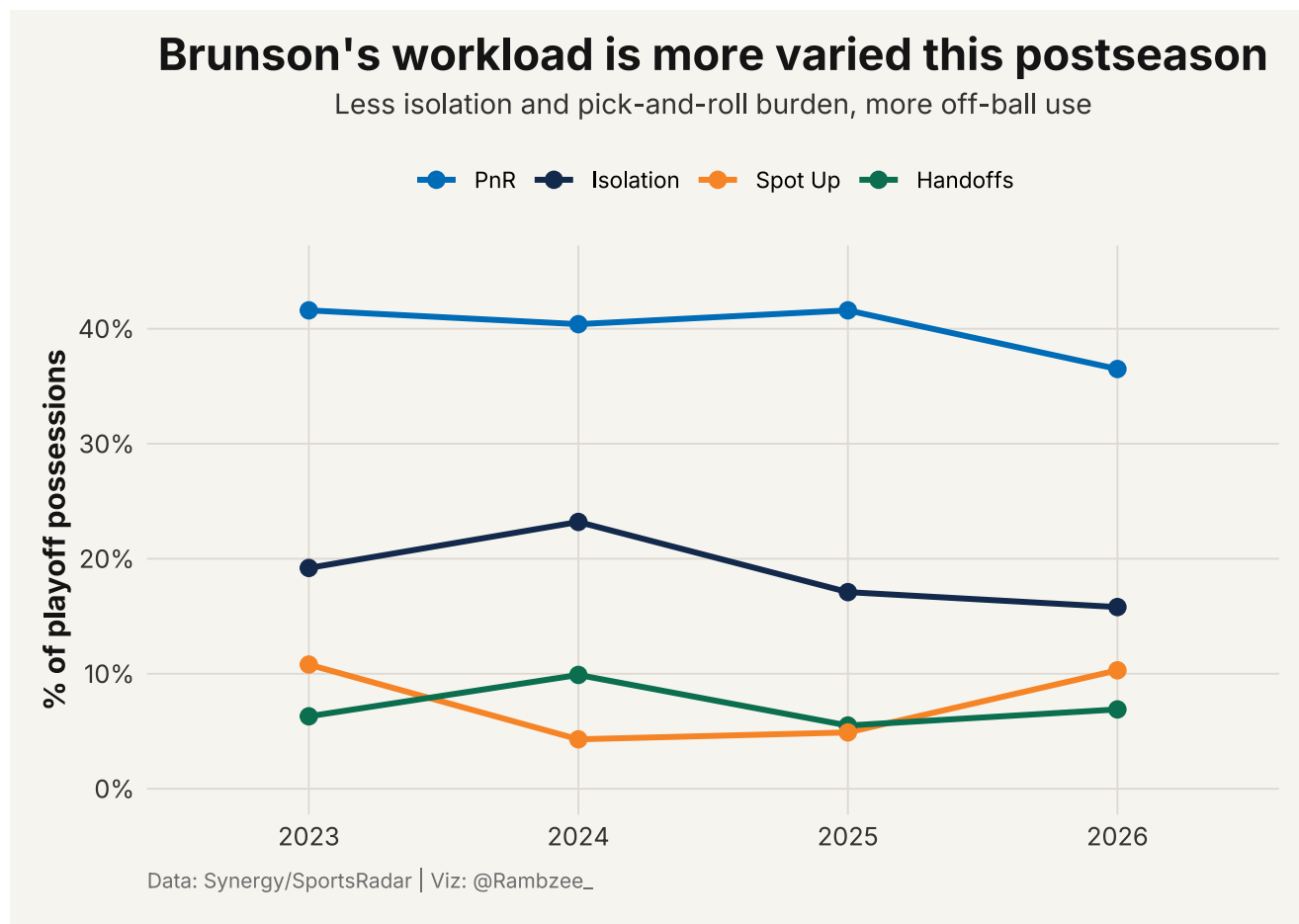


Figure 4: Jalen Brunson playoff playtype distribution - through Game 2 vs Philadelphia; Game 3 excluded because OG was out

Brunson is still the engine of the offense. The difference is that New York is no longer asking him to create every advantage himself.

Through the first 8 playoff games with OG available, Brunson's workload looked noticeably more balanced than in previous playoff runs. His pick-and-roll share remained high, but it fell from the 40–42% range of prior postseasons to 36.5%, while his isolation burden also declined. At the same time, his spot-up usage climbed back above 10%.

KAT's playmaking and OG's finishing have allowed the Knicks to involve Brunson in more varied actions instead of forcing him to survive impossible possessions over and over again. That balance is a major part of what raises New York's ceiling when fully healthy.

Where There's Still Questions

Mikal Bridges

Table 9: Mikal Bridges' playoff reset

Window	Games	PPG	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	TOV	+/-
Games 1-5	5	7.2	53.3%	43.8%	26.7%	0.8	1.2	-2.2
Games 6-9	4	20.5	78.7%	75%	53.8%	1.8	0.0	+20.3

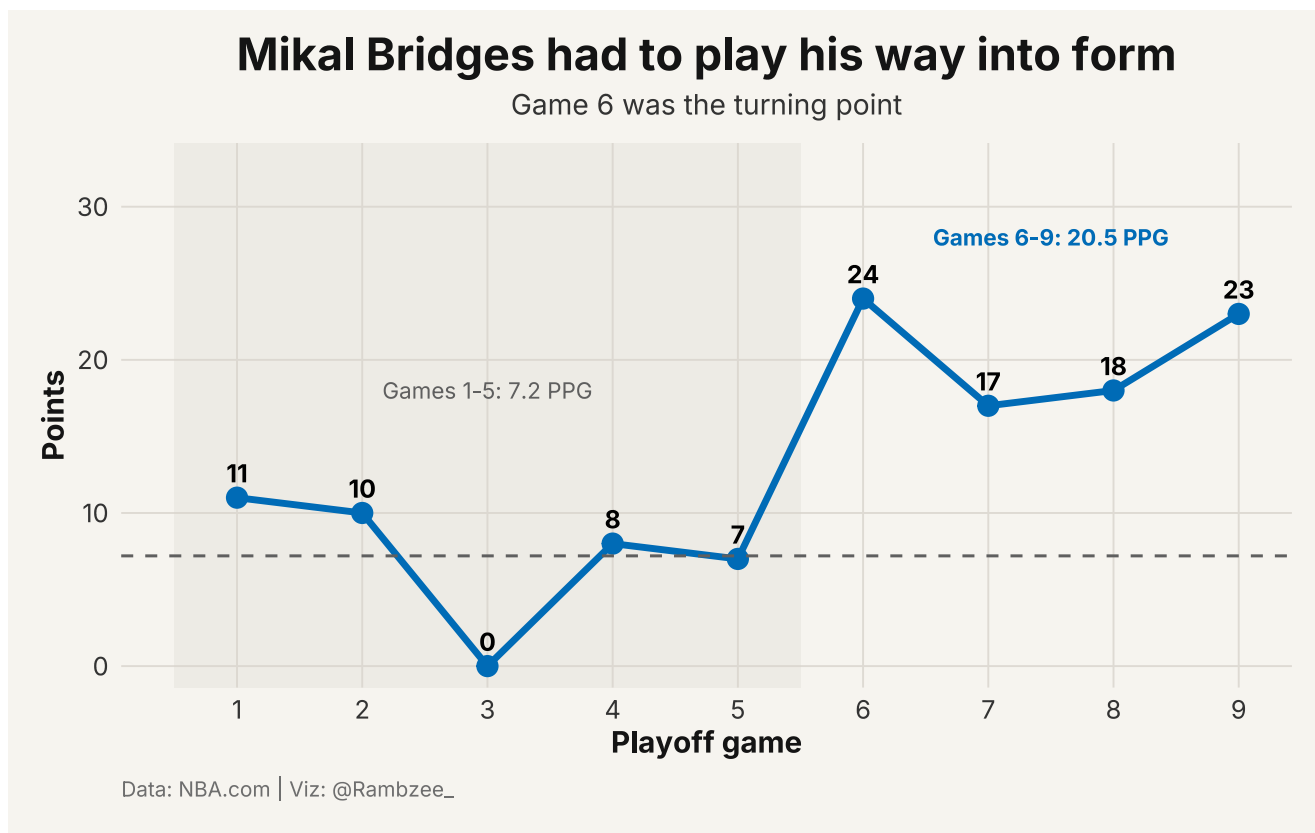


Figure 5: Mikal Bridges game-by-game playoff scoring progression

Bridges is the biggest variable left in the rotation. The last four games have been excellent, but the opening five still matter. Against Atlanta, the passivity, settling, and uneven pressure all showed up.

The recent jump is encouraging. He looks more comfortable, more involved, and more willing to punish space. The concern is that a lot of the surge is still jumper-reliant. When the shot is falling, he looks like the missing piece. When it is not, the Knicks still need him to impact the game without drifting.

That becomes even more important if OG misses extended time. New York does not need Bridges to be a third star every night, but it may need more of the Games 6–9 version to survive this series and keep its title path alive until OG returns.

Josh Hart

[H]

Table 10: Josh Hart regular-season and playoff split comparison

Window	PTS	AST	REB	STL	TS%	2P%	3P%	FTA	TOV	+/-
First 67 Games	12.0	4.8	7.4	1.1	61.4%	57.9%	41.2%	1.9	1.9	+3.1
Last 9 Games	9.6	4.6	9.0	1.7	48.1%	57.4%	20.6%	2.1	2.1	+12.8

[H]

Table 11: Josh Hart playoff Net Points profile

Player	G	Offensive Net Points	Defensive Net Points	Overall Net Points
Josh Hart	9	-18	+16	-2

Hart has mostly remained the same player he was during the regular season, for better and worse. The rebounding, defensive activity, and general chaos still create value even when the scoring disappears, which is why his defensive Net Points profile remains strong.

The issue is that the offensive decline has become difficult to ignore. His efficiency and three-point shooting have cratered in the playoffs, and unlike Bridges, there has not been a real counter-surge yet. New York can survive some offensive limitations because of everything else Hart provides, but the current version places more pressure on the rest of the lineup to carry the spacing and scoring load.

Net Points: Who Has Impacted Most?

Net Points Definition: Net Points is a play-by-play based metric that assigns credit and blame for every possession while a player is on the floor, capturing scoring, turnovers, defense, and context beyond the box score. It reflects how much a player actually moved the score, not just what they produced individually.

Table 12: Knicks playoff Net Points, minimum seven games

Player	G	Offense	Defense	Overall
Karl-Anthony Towns	9	+28	+21	+48
Jalen Brunson	9	+34	+9	+43
OG Anunoby	8	+29	+13	+42
Mikal Bridges	9	+11	+5	+15
Jose Alvarado	8	+4	+6	+10
Jordan Clarkson	9	+1	+5	+7
Mitchell Robinson	8	-1	+5	+4
Josh Hart	9	-18	+16	-2
Miles McBride	9	-12	+9	-3
Landry Shamet	9	-6	+3	-3

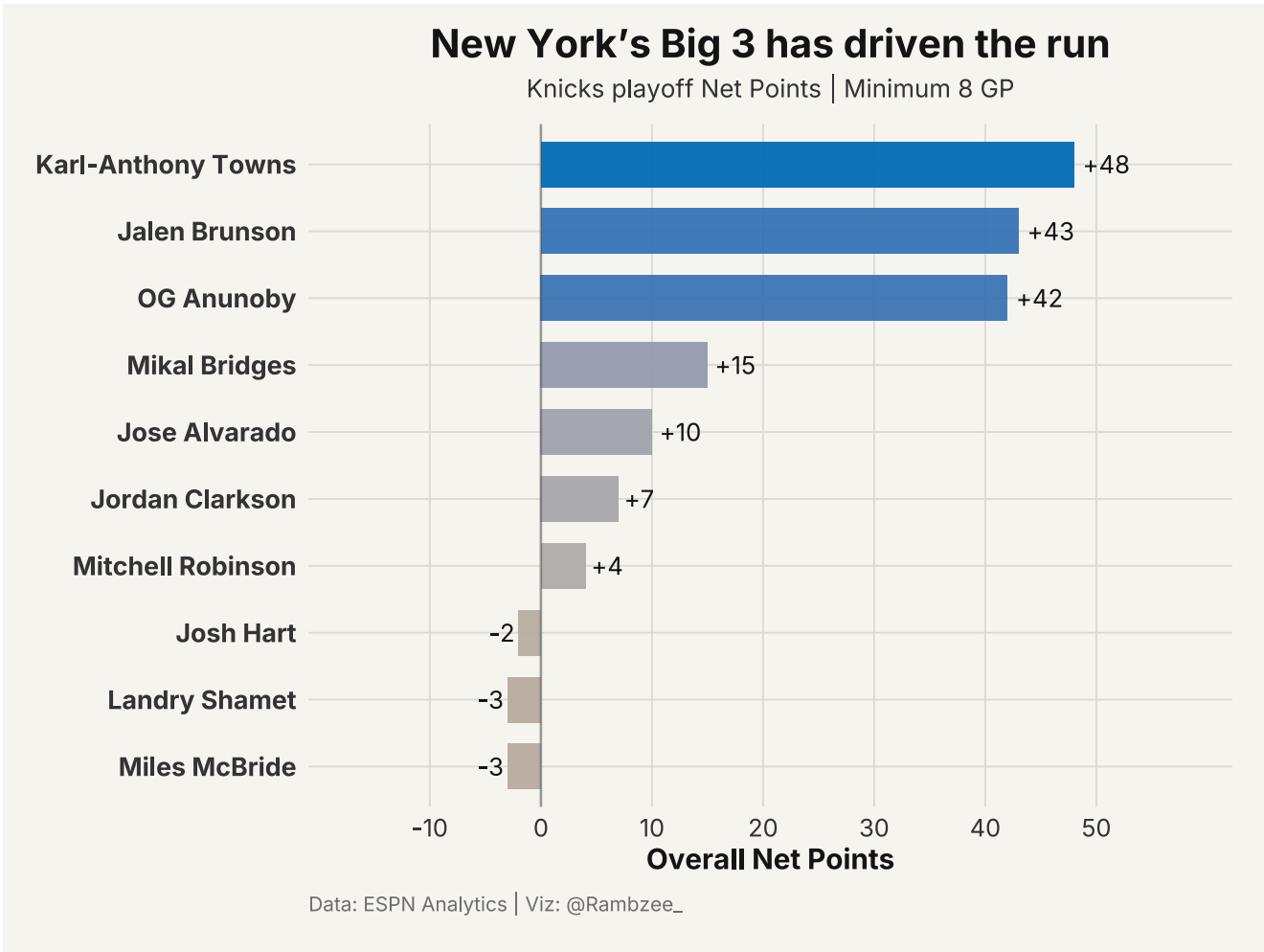


Figure 6: Knicks playoff Net Points by player

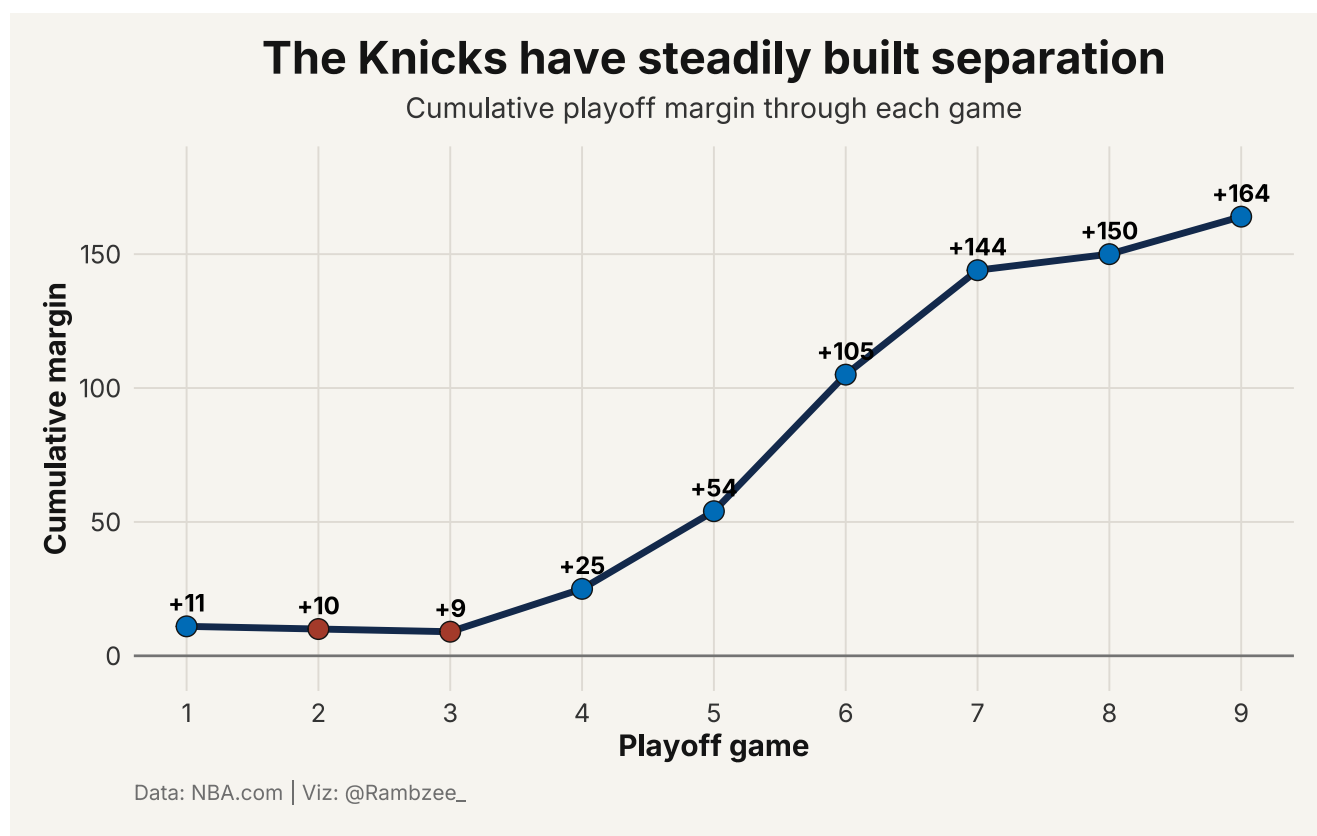


Figure 7: Knicks playoff cumulative margin over time

The broader picture is still encouraging. New York’s best players have moved the score the most, and the cumulative margin shows how sharply the Knicks separated after the first three games.

Still, a championship run depends on the unresolved pieces. OG’s health matters. Bridges needs to keep trending toward the Games 6–9 version, especially if OG misses more time. Hart has to give them enough offense to keep his defensive value on the floor.

But the foundation is there. The Knicks have defended, created multiple areas of margin, and won their minutes like a team with a legitimate path forward.

Conclusion

The Knicks do not need every number to hold exactly where it is. OG will not shoot 75.5% true shooting forever. Mikal’s Games 6–9 surge still needs a larger sample. KAT’s efficiency will be tested as defenses adjust. Brunson will see tougher perimeter coverages the deeper this run goes.

Even with those concerns, New York’s playoff formula looks more complete than it has in years. They can win through Brunson, through Towns, through defense, or through the margins.

That opportunity brings pressure. This is not just a nice “Knicks are back” story anymore. It is their clearest chance to win the East.